

Collaboration-Based Learning Environments using Augmented Reality

by
Sebastian Gil Parga

Submitted to the Department of Creative Technologies
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ABSTRACT

The developments of the “kinetic theory” of gases made within the last ten years have enabled it to account satisfactorily for many of the laws of gases. The mathematical deductions of Clausius, Maxwell and others, based upon the hypothesis of a gas composed of molecules acting upon each other at impact like perfectly elastic spheres, have furnished expressions for the laws of its elasticity, viscosity, conductivity for heat, diffusive power and other properties. For some of these laws we have experimental data of value in testing the validity of these deductions and assumptions. Next to the elasticity, perhaps the phenomena of the viscosity of gases are best adapted to investigation.¹

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¹Text from Holman (1876): doi:[10.2307/25138434](https://doi.org/10.2307/25138434).

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Write your acknowledgments here.

Biographical Sketch

Silas Whitcomb Holman was born in Harvard, Massachusetts on January 20, 1856. He received his S.B. degree in Physics from MIT in 1876, and then joined the MIT Department of Physics as an Assistant. He became Instructor in Physics in 1880, Assistant Professor in 1882, Associate Professor in 1885, and Full Professor in 1893. Throughout this period, he struggled with increasingly severe rheumatoid arthritis. At length, he was defeated, becoming Professor Emeritus in 1897 and dying on April 1, 1900.

Holman's light burned brilliantly before his tragic and untimely death. He published extensively in thermal physics, and authored textbooks on precision measurement, fundamental mechanics, and other subjects. He established the original Heat Measurements Laboratory. Holman was a much admired teacher among both his students and his colleagues. The reports of his department and of the Institute itself refer to him frequently in the 1880's and 1890's, in tones that gradually shift from the greatest respect to the deepest sympathy.

Holman was a student of Professor Edward C. Pickering, then head of the Physics department. Holman himself became second in command of Physics, under Professor Charles R. Cross, some years later. Among Holman's students, several went on to distinguish themselves, including: the astronomer George E. Hale ('90) who organized the Yerkes and Mt. Wilson observatories and who designed the 200 inch telescope on Mt. Palomar; Charles G. Abbot ('94), also an astrophysicist and later Secretary of the Smithsonian Institution; and George K. Burgess ('96), later Director of the Bureau of Standards.

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List of Acronyms

VR Virtual Reality

AR Augmented Reality

TEL Technology Enhanced Learning

MR Mixed Reality

CSCW Computer Software for Cooperative Work

CL Collaborative Learning

CoP Community of Practice

Chapter 1

Introduction

In the Netflix animated series *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* (Imaishi et al., 2022), the main character attends courses at a prestigious academy that uses advanced technology to boost education and performance. The students gather in a room with Virtual Reality (VR) headsets and connect to the lesson, which is taught by a holographic (and probably powered by artificial intelligence) tutor. The episode does not show the lesson itself (the entire system fails catastrophically when attacked by malware), but the brief scene highlights the vision many people have of a futuristic classroom, one guided by advanced technology and automatization.

Forsler et al. (2024) propose the term “post-digital classroom” to identify the characteristics and trends in education present in a world beyond the adoption of digital technologies. The purpose of this classroom is not anymore to introduce new technologies to students, but to implement them as an essential factor of the learning process. The post-digital classroom is interconnected, social and global. In this scenario, learning goes beyond the physical classroom because it is based on creating relationships between concepts and developing valuable skills rather than acquiring knowledge. It is also a classroom where information is detached from the physical learning institute, and access to facts and sources is, ideally, immediate, ubiquitous and democratic.

The classroom has also become hybrid. There is little distinction between network-based lessons and the face-to-face spaces associated with schools and universities (Goodyear et al., 2004). Hybrid and blended approaches blur the distinctions between learning in an online setting and learning in a classroom. In both instances, information is at hand in the network, students can easily connect to peers and mentors, distance and time constraints are less meaningful and knowledge is presented in a multimedia format that needs a technological backbone to be created and shared (Rivoltella, 2008; Shank, 2005).

This thesis explores the use of technology in such post-digital classrooms, specifically, AR within the context of mobile computing. Moreover, this research will analyse the creation of effective learning spaces, those places where students can build, personalise and control all the activities they engage with (Gourlay & Oliver, 2016). Learning spaces are interesting tools at the disposal of students because these are spaces that can exist outside the norm of a typical classroom, they are more fluid, less structured and can easily connect to other similar spaces (Nørgård & Hilli, 2022). The proposal of this research is that AR can be used to boost the way students build and interact with their own learning spaces and can also



Figure 1.1: Virtual Classroom in Cyberpunk: Edgerunners

offer educators another option to be integrated in the construction of a lesson that capitalises the characteristics of the aforementioned post-digital classrooms.

Within the field of Technology Enhanced Learning (TEL), AR and related technologies were chosen as a focus of interest because of their intrinsic relationship with space. The initial example scene of Cyberpunk: Edgerunners serves to illustrate the collective idea of what could be achieved in the future with technologies like VR and AR: the possibility of creating an entire new space, suited for the needs of the classroom or the students. It is a space that is shared, in which information and interactions flow between users and that can be controlled at will by students and teachers. In reality, the technology is not quite there yet, especially in terms of fidelity and immersion (Checa & Bustillo, 2020; Hamad & Jia, 2022). What can be explored right now is the creation of interesting synthetic environments that facilitate or allow experiences that are not possible in the common classroom. This process is limited more by the creativity and expertise of the developer rather than by the technology, and therefore can be explored easier and in more detail.

AR, compared to VR, has a more direct relationship with the *real*, physical space and with the context of the user. Instead of an isolated immersion, AR creates a connection with the environment based on image detection, data and visualizations. This natural expression of the technology is where the value of AR can be explored in relation to the creation of innovative learning spaces. The technology not only has interesting capabilities for visualization and interaction, it also allows an easier implementation of shared, social components that can be used to build activities based on cooperative simulations, sharing knowledge and the creation of communities, all crucial elements for the construction of effective learning spaces (Bligh & Crook, 2017).

The research is positioned then in the conjunction of these three fields: Learning spaces, TEL and AR. The guiding goal is to understand how students are using technology to learn,

and how [AR](#) can be used to boost that process. [AR](#) shines at creating immersive experiences that can be shared with others and that consider the physical context of the user. I want to use this collaborative space as an educational tool that takes advantage of the inherent social aspects of learning, building and sharing knowledge.

No modern classroom is free of technology, the simple act of taking notes on a paper already implies a set of technological developments needed to put knowledge into written form. Networking and information technologies are just another set of tools at the disposition of any student. A personal learning space can incorporate different software tools, many of which are now ubiquitous and almost indispensable in any learning activity: text processors, multimedia editing tools, web browsers and document readers, plus any specialised tool that the learning subject requires. But that learning space is also built around more elements, some of them equally indispensable for some students. People need a space to work, access to different amenities, access to textbooks, information and teachers. Some may need a quiet space to concentrate, or, on the contrary, may need access to music, to snacks or to a separate place to periodically take a break. The construction of a learning space involves many different elements, some more technological than others, and its effectiveness is based more on the integration of those elements than anything else (Lu & Churchill, 2013; Reinius et al., 2021). This research aims at identifying how to properly integrate [AR](#) in the construction of a learning space, which is already composed by a complex web of many other objects, tools and circumstances.

As a researcher. I have explored in the past the way different technologies can be used as part of those learning spaces, either with tools for online learning scenarios or using [VR](#) to create a digital space to explore multimedia content (Gil Parga, 2015). This current project can be seen as a way to expand on the work done before, identifying ways to adapt a different technology, to apply lessons learned and to explore new avenues of research. In particular, it is an opportunity to expand from personalized learning environments into social learning spaces, and explore the role of the community in teaching and learning.

It was clear in the work done previously and through some notable literature like Richards (2023) and Long and Ehrmann (2005) that the construction of learning spaces is always mediated by the community around us, even when creating a space as personal as possible. Even nowadays that we live in a post-pandemic world where we seek remote, personalised and secure ways of learning, it has become clear that the social aspect of learning is a crucial element in the equation (Baber, 2021; De Felice et al., 2023). The aim of this research is to delve deeper into the social elements that influence the construction of a learning space, how the students negotiate the process of learning with others and the benefits of collaboration, as well as the challenges it conveys.

This is also a technological enquiry. Having explored [VR](#) in the past, it was clear that this family of technologies offer interesting advantages by using complex visuals, new forms of presenting information and more natural interactions suited for the exploration and experimentation with 3D spaces. These technologies also present curious challenges, especially in the usability front. For instance, the public has not yet developed a strong relation or consistent literacy with the technology (Özgen et al., 2021), which creates accessibility problems. And those technologies that leverage common and accessible platforms, like mobile devices, risk carrying with them problems associated with the excessive and pervasive presence of such technologies (Forsler & Guyard, 2025; Petrucco, 2021).

The following introductory chapter will expand this brief exploration of the context and motivation for the research proposed, outlining the main research goal and the reasoning behind the formulation of the selected research questions. There will be a brief exposition of the methodology followed to build possible answers, the significance of this research and why the answers to the questions proposed can provide important insights about the way we use technology to learn and how we design technological tools for the classroom. It will be followed by a summary of the results obtained and the contributions achieved, as well as the scope and limitations of the work done. The chapter will conclude with a description of the structure of this thesis document.

1.1 Context

AR technologies are positioned somewhere in the middle of the reality-simulation spectrum proposed by Milgram et al. (1995), a model for display technologies used to show digital or physical data in virtual or synthetic realities. The main characteristic of AR in this spectrum is the incorporation of the real world as part of the experience, making use of different image recognition and composition techniques to identify features in the physical space and overlay them with digital information.

Schmalstieg (2016) adds another layer of analysis to the description of AR-like technologies by using the ubiquitous computing spectrum proposed by Weiser (1991). The model positions different implementations of AR depending on the use of more static or more mobile deployment platforms. In one end of the spectrum are applications that can only be used in singular static terminals, while the other side contemplate platform-independent mobile technologies and ubiquitous systems. Figure 1.2 shows examples of this distribution as proposed by the authors.

In this bi-directional spectrum we can find mobile AR as a family of technologies that offer an in-between mixture of virtual and physical elements in which location, place and context are additional inputs used for interaction with the synthetic reality. Any technology in the spectrum will offer a variety of characteristics that align with one or more descriptions at a time. Mixed Reality (MR), for example, are seen as an extension of both VR and AR, offering seamless interaction and connectivity between the real and the simulated world. It is a blurry line that often must be analysed in a case-by-case approach. No matter what label is used to describe a technology, some agreed upon characteristics must be present for it to be categorized as AR, as stated by Azuma (1997):

- A combination of real space and digital information.
- Interaction with the simulation in real time.
- The simulation is done in a 3D space.

With these descriptors it is possible to position the used of the technology in different fields, independent of the labels used to identify it. Based on the themes introduced in the opening statement of the chapter, the goal is to analyse AR as CSCW. For this task, a useful analytical tool is the classification of CSCW technologies proposed by Rodden (1991)

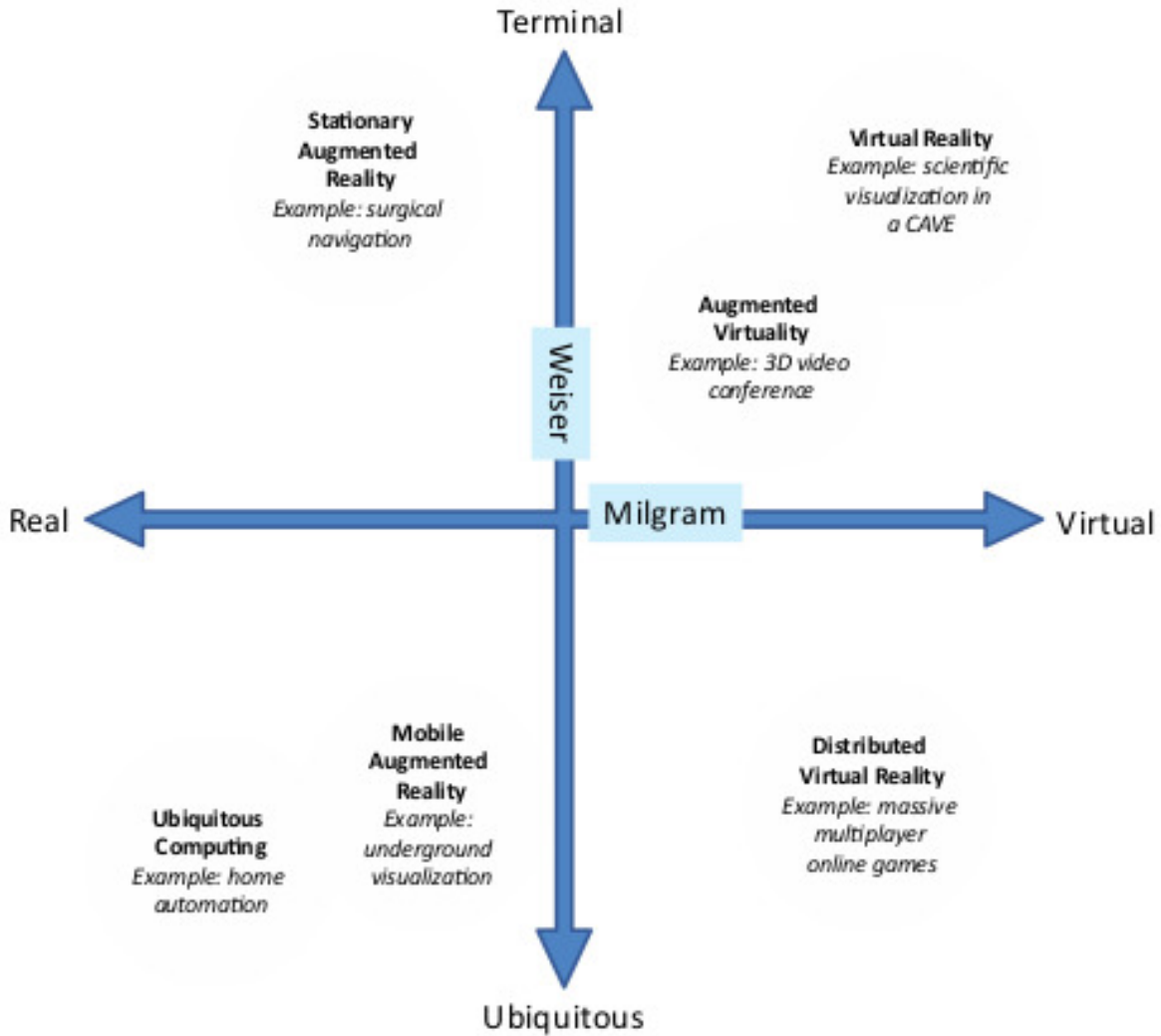


Figure 1.2: AR in the Milgram-Weiser Spectrum (Schmalstieg, 2016).

in terms of the point in time and space where the collaboration is taking place. Figure 1.3 shows examples of different systems that can be found in each quadrant of the classification, which indicate whether the activity is synchronous or asynchronous, remote or co-located.

Complementarily, Kiyokawa et al. (2002) offer two important elements present in a collaborative activity: communication and tasks spaces. In the communication space, people exchange information and can sustain formal and informal conversations. In the task space, the actual cooperative work is done. Those spaces can be unified or separated, and they can be physical, virtual or in a mixed state. Independent of the nature of each individual space, both need to be present for collaboration to succeed.

Based on these classification models, it is possible to define the main field of interest of this research as the use of AR in a mixed task space for face-to-face collaborative learning, which implies synchronous activities in a co-located space. In this setting it should be possible to use the capabilities of AR for visualization and interaction with the physical space to

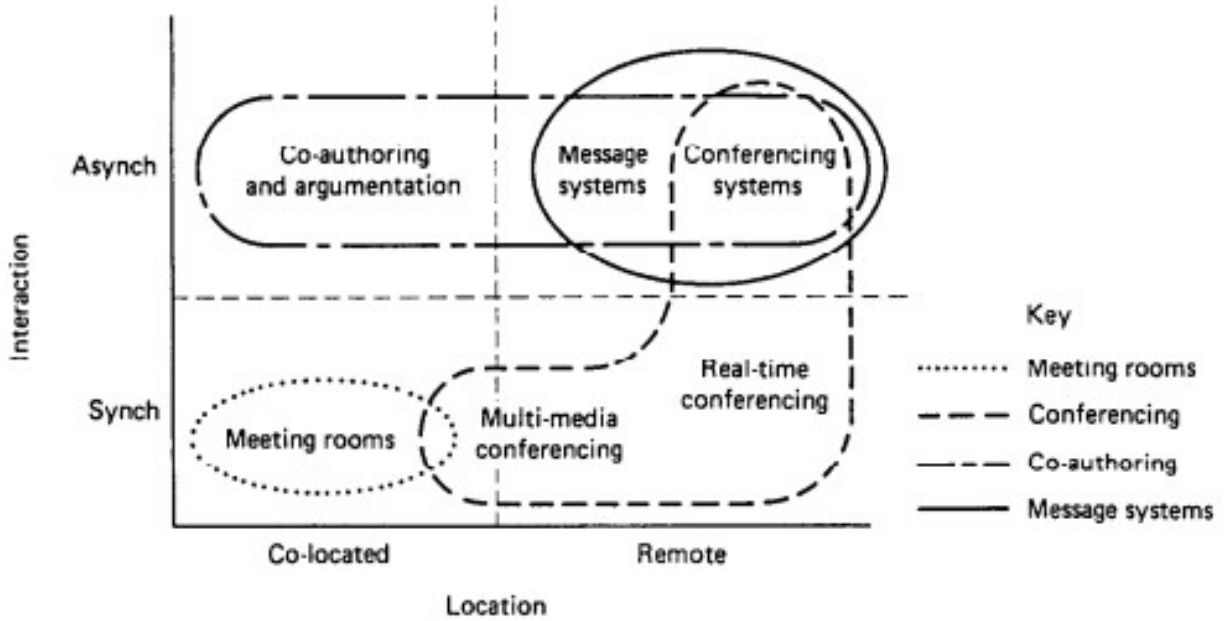


Figure 1.3: Classification of CSCW Systems by Rodden (1991).

augment the collaboration process in terms of:

- Activities related to the communication space, the flow of information and the creation of knowledge in the group.
- The use of the physical space as an asset in the collaborative process.
- Management of the collaborative process itself and the structures that can be created to facilitate effective teamwork and cooperation.
- Guidelines to acquire and refine skills related to teamwork and collaboration.

The main proposal is that the unique characteristics that AR provides in the field of MR are well suited to experiences in co-located collaboration, and that a learning design that is using a collaborative approach can benefit from an AR tool mediating in the communication and tasks spaces of the activity.

The interest in collaborative learning derives from the analysis of the use of AR in education and the tendencies identified in the available literature. It was possible to note that AR is often used as a tool to explore concepts and practices in hands-on approaches that apply previous knowledge in different situations and contexts. Unfortunately, the technology is seldom used in cooperative scenarios, despite the tendency to use mobile platforms for deployment (Gil Parga et al., 2023).

Collaborative learning is a subject rich in discussion. The conversation can focus on the benefits of groupwork in the classroom like promoting different points of view, facilitating complex understanding of a topic and creating the space for an integral development of the student (Smith et al., 1992; Van Wyk & Haffejee, 2017). On the other hand, the challenges associated with collaborative work are also amply explored (Baloche & Brody, 2017; Buchs

et al., 2017; Popov et al., 2012), and there is plenty discussion around issues related to classroom management, inclusivity, effective assessment and good practices.

Many studies have identified and compiled the advantages of using AR and MR as learning tools. For instance, Penn and Ramnarain (2023) offer an analysis of the educational foundations used to design learning interventions. They conclude that most projects converged into constructivist foundations and embodiment theory, opting to create spaces for students to experience and explore the learning subject, with an emphasis on immersion, practice and hands-on interactions. Despite these commonalities, the authors also remarked that most reports do not mention explicitly or do not rationalize the theoretical background of the intervention. They also note that a lot of researchers still hold the idea that introducing a new technology in the classroom is enough to reap its benefits, without caring to build or follow a proper integration plan.

This issue acquires even more relevance now that the mediation of different technologies in the collaboration process has grown due to the Covid-19 pandemic, which forced a quick and often poorly planned implementation of remote learning (Drueke et al., 2021; Nuere et al., 2021). Over time, this prompted the re-design and re-thinking of how to use technology to support the sudden disruption in learning methodologies and approaches (Adi Badiozaman et al., 2020; Fischer et al., 2020). The forced isolation also highlighted the importance of social spaces in the constructions of learning environments, and the need to provide those social interactions even in online spaces (McInnerney & Roberts, 2004; Walas-Trębacz et al., 2025).

The post-pandemic classroom is dealing now with the need to balance the advantages of online spaces with the problems associated with socialization solely mediated by technology, which tends to be asynchronous and impersonal. There is value in the physical space for the learning process (Paechter & Maier, 2010; Petchamé et al., 2021; Thai et al., 2020), and a technology that is able to connect the physical and the digital is worthy of a deeper exploration to identify proper approaches and successful use cases.

The idea is not to oversimplify the presence of digital technologies in the classroom, nor follow a misguided tendency of selling all the benefits of a technology without acknowledging its problems. If the proposal is to identify the effects of a collaborative learning design mediated by AR, it is important to also identify all the problems that derive from this approach, either because of the issues that naturally come from teamworking scenarios in the classroom or the negative behaviours that the excessive use of digital technologies promotes, especially in the specific environment of mobile platforms.

With that context just detailed, it is possible to summarize the goal of this research as: The construction of an AR tool that serves as aid in a collaborative learning setting by helping students to communicate and develop teamworking skills. This can be achieved by means of interactivity, visualization, immersion and augmentation of the physical space.

1.2 Research Structure

The goal of the research can be justified by an abundance of literature showing the elements of AR used in the past to offer distinctive value for learning, and the open opportunities to explore and understand better the development of multi-user AR experiences for collaboration.

The nature of the proposal implies that the research has two main fronts:

- In the *technological* front, the goal is to build a software solution that considers the development challenges of an [AR](#) tool in a multi-user and multi-platform environment, and the specific requirements derived from the learning goals proposed in the educational front.
- In the *educational* front, the goal is to identify, describe and develop a case study based on collaborative learning, and to analyse the behaviours that students develop when learning in a collaborative environment mediated by technology, comparing the use of [AR](#) with other tools or approaches.

1.2.1 Research Questions

The guiding research questions of this project are aimed at obtaining information of what constitutes an effective collaborative learning design using [AR](#). The answers can be stated in terms of learning goals, interaction design and integration plans with the classroom. The questions also seek information about how [AR](#) is creating an effect in the behaviour of the students while using the tool for learning. These behaviours can be related to communication, socialization, planning and engagement with the learning material. The main research question will be stated as follows:

MQ: How does the behaviour of a group of students changes when using an [AR](#) tool designed to aid in the achievement of a learning goal framed in a collaborative learning scenario?

To guide the implementation of the tool through a strong design, a lot of information can be extracted from current literature and from previous projects using similar approaches. Information gathered from real and incremental usage off the system also offers valuable insights in terms of usability, viability and end-user perception. With this in mind, an iterative development process is proposed to facilitate the exploration of ideas regarding interaction design and a proper fit to the learning scenario where the tool is going to be used.

The implementation of the tool alone is insufficient to answer the main question. For this purpose, a case study research methodology is proposed with the objective of identifying and describing a strong context in which collaboration is used for learning and in which the implementation of the [AR](#) tool can be contrasted and compared to other approaches. In this context it is also easier to observe more natural behaviours from the students and the observations will show results closer to how the tool could be used in a real deployment.

It is very important to carefully select a case study that not only offers unique circumstances valuable enough to be analysed in detail but also has the proper learning context to explore the themes of interest of this research project. Although the specific learning field of a prospective case study is not that important, it needs certain characteristics, independently if it is developed through a single activity, a section of a course or through the whole course. The case study must incorporate all the following elements:

- A clear learning goal, either as a whole or as a step to achieve a more complex goal. Assessment activities alone are not enough because the research objectives require the observation of collaborative learning, not the development of a single teamwork activity.
- A collaborative approach to the learning activity. Students must be expected to work in groups to achieve the task, or at least, to have access to a space for collaboration in the development of the activity, even if it is individual in nature.

Ideally, the case study also contemplates the process of learning to collaborate, either as its own learning goal or willing to implement such an objective as a secondary goal. This is not essential, but the current proposal borrows a lot of elements from learning designs about developing collaborative skills. If the selected case study already seeks learning objectives in this venue, then the proposed intervention could offer more value.

The selected case study offers an excellent opportunity, not only to experiment with the proposed thematic of collaboration and technology mediated learning, but because it is also a unique and interesting context in terms of learning design and the opportunities for coordinated teamwork, project development and innovative use of technology.

The Industry Project course of the Built Environments program is a complex scenario that provides students with opportunities to develop industry-level skills through a project-based approach. It presents the opportunity to intervene in the whole course and to use the software solution proposed across different stages of development of the course and different learning objectives, an ideal scenario for varied observations and a rich space for experimentation and discussion.

A set of secondary question can be described that will help to focus the data gathering stages of the research, especially those related to the observations and activities in the context of the case study:

SQ1: What differences in behaviour can be observed between students collaborating using the [AR](#) tool and those that are not?

SQ2: What differences the students report in their perception of the activities done in the course between those using the [AR](#) tool and those who are not?

SQ3: How does the collaboration and communication process changes between students using the [AR](#) tool and those that are not?

SQ4: What differences can be observed in the end results of the course between all the different collaborative approaches observed, especially of those that incorporate the [AR](#) tool?

The focus of the observation process should be in identifying behaviours and processes rather than only differences in the end results, that is, the final assessment of the course project. Relying solely on possible improvements to grades or assessments can be a valid but flawed tool to understand the effects of a technology in the classroom (Dalziel, 1998; Katz et al., 2017). Additionally, the selected case study proposes a complex course to analyse, where several and diverse factors influence the work of the students. Taking this into

consideration is why a positive or negative result does not tell the full story and why is more important to observe the whole learning process, from planning to development, documenting the behaviours developed to fulfil tasks and reach goals. The objective is to identify if the [AR](#) tool proposed is an influence, either positive or negative, and if it provides a more meaningful impact to the learning process as a whole and not only to the end assessments.

Assuming there are actual substantial differences between the students using the [AR](#) tool and those that are not, then it is also important to ask:

SQ5: What elements of a technological intervention using [AR](#) create the most impact in changing the behaviours, perceptions or results of the students?

SQ6: What elements of a multi-user [AR](#) tool creates the most impact in changing the behaviours, perceptions or results of students collaborating and communicating in a learning scenario?

These last questions are meant to provide an evaluation to the decisions taken in the development of the [AR](#) tool, especially the multi-user interactions, and how the tool was integrated to the learning design of the course. It also offers the possibility to highlight elements of the tool that could be polished or reframed in future work.

1.2.2 Scope and Limitations

Using a case study methodology, it is possible to approach the research questions through a qualitative lens, which is better suited for understanding the information gathered about behaviours, relationships developed between students and their subjective perceptions of the course, the activities developed, and the results obtained. All those elements would be hard or contra productive to try and quantify. In this light, it is important to acknowledge the limitations in scope and reach derived by the selected methodologies.

In relation to the software development aspect, it is important to establish the scope of the product as a prototype that explores the ideas of collaboration and multi-user [AR](#). A thorough analysis of the design and architecture of the software was conducted to describe different possible approaches and solutions suited to the context and the needs of the tool, keeping an analytical mindset for all the ramifications and consequences derived from the implementation of a particular idea or design.

In terms of the concrete implementation of the software, the work was undertaken by a sole developer and limited in time and resources related to access to the case study. Most of the design and architectural proposals were tested via mock-ups or wireframe prototypes (Coleman & Goodwin, 2017; Sutipitakwong & Jamsri, 2020) in pseudo-structured test scenarios, aiming primarily for quick feedback and impressions rather than structured data. This allowed constant iteration and exploration of different ideas. The final implementation of the software prioritized showing the most critical use cases and the most relevant interactions with the tool, most of them tailored for specific observation sessions.

This approach had an important influence in the structure of the observation process and the nature of the data gathered, fomenting a more guided use of the tool and a more structured response from the participants rather than the free observation initially intended.

This was an acceptable concession made to facilitate the development process and to give the participants early and consistent access to the tool, albeit in a more incomplete state. This also minimized the disruption to academic work while maximizing the opportunities for meaningful observation in the available time.

There is also an inherent problem in the development of a case study in relation to the applicability of the results, generalization and subjectivity. The Industry Project course was chosen because it fulfilled all the characteristics needed for the research, but convenience aside, the course also provides a unique opportunity to analyse a collaborative learning design in action, with scenarios that could be extrapolated to other similar contexts, but also a unique take on the design of project-based learning and assessment, as well as a complex context for implementation and challenges that had to be tackled, all elements worth of a detailed analysis.

Nonetheless, it is important to identify the limitations of using one sole case study, which can be summarized as issues with the transferability and applicability of the data gathered. Other factors that impact heavily the nature of the data are the overall seniority of the students, which were all close to finish their studies and the lack of a concrete study plan of the course, which focused more on the development of the project as its main teaching instrument, offering just a relatively vague and general set of learning goals.

Chapter 3 will describe in more detail the scope and limitations of the case study, as well as the measures taken to minimize or acknowledge the flaws and restrictions of the chosen framework. For now, these issues can be summarized the main limitations related to focusing the software development into a gradual an iterative progression of a prototype and the validity of the case study in terms of the characteristics needed for the research and the unique value it offers for analysis and discussion.

1.3 Significance and Contributions

The technological environment in which we found ourselves right now evolves rapidly and at large steps. Despite critics of stagnation, the classroom evolves and adapts in response and constantly tries to understand how the available technologies can improve the way we learn (Watters, 2021). It is not always a positive relationship, it is often marred by overselling products and forcing a technological implementation without a plan and a proper consideration of the context and needs of the classroom (Cochrane, 2012; Odunaike et al., 2013). Currently, it is also a field that experiences a lot of social scrutiny as we react to the idea that we have become somewhat addicted to digital content and to the devices used to consume it (Gui & Büchi, 2021; Liu et al., 2022). In a context in which we are banning the use of smartphones in the classrooms and obtaining somewhat positive results because of it (Rahali et al., 2024), why, then, rely on a proposal that fundamentally uses that technology?

As Murray and Perez (2014) establish, exposure to technology does not equal comprehension. In an age in which almost all aspects of life are mediate by digital activities, it is important to create a positive, critical and informed relationship with the technology that we have to use in our daily lives, and that relationship does not develops naturally (Margaryan et al., 2011; Selwyn, 2009). This is a task that can and should be executed in the classroom at different levels of schooling, in different contexts and at appropriate age and field depths.

The classroom is the ideal scenario to create and nourish this relationship in a structured and positive way, yet this is a factor that is seen as lacking in education institutes, especially in middle and high school (Burton et al., 2015; Jeffrey et al., 2011).

This project is an exploration of that philosophy, and an experimentation with a technological design that uses mobile devices in a healthy approach that promotes the development of skills needed today. Although the capacities of AR as a learning tool are evident, this endeavour needs to follow a due process. It is important to properly understand how to use the technology and what elements of the design and implementation process need to be highlighted and worked on to create that intended positive impact. The technology does offer a big opportunity to enhance and reframe the way we communicate and work together, but it also has proven to impose certain challenges that have to be analysed, understood and dealt with.

This document will describe the proposal, design, implementation, observation and analysis activities done in the development of an AR tool for collaborative learning and the test deployment conducted focused on developing skills related to teamwork and effective communication. The development of this research was carried in two interlocked steps. In one hand is the design and implementation of the software WorkshopAR, an AR tool used as a companion in the face-to-face work that was part of the activities proposed for the Industry Project course. Specifically, the software was used during the weekly group sessions of work that the students held for the development of three different assessment milestones in the course-long project.

The development of WorkshopAR consisted in solving two main issues, both related to the technological front of the research. First, there was a design challenge that required identifying the most common interactions performed in an AR environment for cooperative work. Different use cases were identified that were unique for this context and that posed an interesting design challenge, like sharing information, sharing and coordinating resources, managing the status of the team and coordinating the development of a task. A user-centred interaction design process was used to outline solutions for the identified use cases based on important restrictions and particularities of the problem.

This stage was accomplished through a detailed exercise of user-centred design, a process meant to identify ideas and decisions born from the direct interactions of the users with prototypes and mock-ups, a structured process for gathering feedback, integrating the user in the design loop and refining ideas in an iterative process. The results obtained highlighted interesting issues and ideas related to multi-platform interactions, the expectation of users when presented with familiar and unfamiliar controls, complications related to interactions in a 3D space and the integration of the tool in the overall workflow of the students.

The second focus in the development of WorkshopAR was the technical challenge of creating a multi-user, shared AR space. Several commercially available frameworks and APIs were explored, such as the AR Foundation suit provided by the Unity game engine and the Lightship API provided by Niantic. It was possible to extract valuable insights about the current state of the development of AR tools, especially in the field of education, and it was possible to describe the lessons learned while integrating the development process with the educational goals of the course. An effort was made to relate the results obtained to those reported in similar studies by identifying common and divergent results and issues, especially those related to finding the technology distracting and the technical development of the tool

too detached from the role of the educator.

Parallel to the construction of WorkshopAR was the development of the case study and the design of the intervention of the Industry Project course. In the design phase, the course was analysed based on the written material available and on interviews with the teaching staff. This information was used to guide the development of WorkshopAR and to identify the instances in the progression of the course in which the intervention could create more impact without disrupting too much the academic activities of the students. It was also an opportunity to detail and analyse the learning design of the course and to understand the context in which the observations were going to take place.

During the observation phase it was possible to obtain detailed observations of the work done by the students with and without the AR tool, about the development of the project through the conception, design and implementation phases, to adapt elements of the tool to better suit the circumstances of the course and to observe the role of the teaching staff in the development of the course and as part of the usage of the tool. This helped to create a rich record to report in the case study and plenty points of analysis and discussion.

The analysis phase used the recorded information from the observation stage plus all the material that could be recollected from the execution of the course. This material included the written communication given to the students via the official channels of the course, the workshops executed during the semester as material to help in the development of the project and the final products created by the students, such as presentations, reports and designs. The observations were also complemented by a set of semi-structured interviews to the students and the teaching staff. The interviews focused on gathering better records of issues related to the personal perceptions about the use of technology and the collaborative activities of the course.

From the observations obtained and the analysis of the results it was possible to formulate some possible and satisfactory answers to the research questions. The data points to interesting behaviours promoted by the intervention, such as students creating a more structured work process when the tool prompted or encourage them to do it. It was also observed that this enforced structure helped the students with the organization of activities, prompting good practices for communication and the organization of ideas and plans.

But the structure also prompted some unintended behaviours, like a tendency to create a hierarchical organization of the group around the student managing the tool, which was not in tune with the objectives of the course. The app also forced the students to be aware of their phones more than they were planning or willing to do, highlighting a current trend among students of regulating their phone consumption. It was also noticed that the tool was most useful for teams struggling with their organization and offered little value for those already with a clear work plan.

Data and observations also provided a lot of insights related to the design of collaborative interactions in virtual 3D environments, to the relationships of students with their phones and how students use different resources, properly or not, to sort out the difficulties of a learning project. It was evident that the social aspect of the collaborative work resonated the most with the students and with the general satisfaction they reported with the activity, giving more importance to the tools created for them to communicate, express ideas and personalize their experience. The case study also opened an unexpected opportunity to analyse the role of the teaching team in the use of the tool, offering a clear path for future work.

1.4 Document Structure

The purpose of this document is to provide an organized recount of the development of this research work, the theoretical background that supported the proposals given and the methodology followed to gather data, analyse it and build a set of answers for the research questions.

This introduction chapter was meant as a summary of all these elements, highlighting the personal motivations behind the chosen research field and the general reasoning that accompanied the design process, the hypothesized and desired results, as well as the methodological pathway taken. Chapter 2 of this document will describe in detail the literature explored that helped in shaping the research questions and that provided the theoretical basis for the educational methods used as anchors for the software implementation.

Chapter 3 details the methodological framework of the research. It briefly explores the research paradigms picked to guide this project and explains the reasoning for choosing them and their relevance to the learning and technical fields this project is based on. The chapter will also offer a complete explanation of the educational front, detailing all the instruments used in the development of the case study. In the technical front, it details the software development methodology followed, especially the reasoning and procedures used for the interaction design process and the methods used to ensure usability, flexibility, expandability and a general user-centred approach.

The description and analysis of the results have been divided in three chapters. The technological front has been described in Chapter 4, where a detailed explanation of the requirement analysis can be found, including use case scenarios and quality objectives. The chapter also details the most relevant elements of the architectural solutions proposed for the tool. Chapter 5 continues with the description of WorkshopAR, now focused on the implementation process followed. The chapter describes the design phase to the development cycles followed to build the software, the testing strategies used to ensure validity and the feedback received by the users during testing and the observations in the case study.

The case study itself is described in Chapter 6, explaining the context of the Industry Project course, the teaching objectives guiding its design and the points of interest for the intervention using WorkshopAR. The chapter will also provide a narrative description of the observations taken over 20 weeks of development of the course, and a preliminary analysis of the data based on the secondary material extracted, like the written documentation, the work produced by the students and the information gathered from the interviews.

The final analysis is presented in Chapter 7 along with the necessary conclusions gathered from the data and the process described in the previous chapters. The chapter will detail what elements of the development of WorkshopAR and the case study support the proposal of AR as a tool to promote positive learning behaviours and effective collaboration, what important technological hurdles were identified and what surprises were found during the development of the project. The chapter will also offer and outline for future work to address the most outstanding issues derived from the research limitations and the problems encountered during the development of the project.

Chapter 2

Literature Review

This project is centred around the concept of Collaborative Learning ([CL](#)): the process of acquiring or creating knowledge as part of a group, and the dynamics that emerge when a team needs to manage participation, the overall success of an activity and the learning objectives that need to be fulfilled (Laal & Ghodsi, [2012](#)). It is also possible to analyse the concept as learning to collaborate, to acquire the skills needed to be an effective team member.

The purpose of this literature review is to find the benefits of adopting a [CL](#) approach in a learning design and the challenges that any educator needs to consider when implementing a strong focus on collaboration. It is also important to understand why collaboration and teamwork are such important skills to develop, why is it so valued in most professional environments and why is there a general feeling that educative institutions are failing in teaching those skills.

This research will approach the field of [CL](#) using the lens of [TEL](#): the use of technologies to support processes or management of teaching and learning (Passey, [2019](#)). Understandably, this is still too wide of a subject, so, a particular focus is set on [AR](#) technologies. The objective will be to understand how [AR](#) can be used in the classroom, and the particularities that it offers in terms of benefits, challenges, common implementations and relevant success stories.

[AR](#) can be a valuable collaborative learning tool based on the unique abilities it possesses. Specifically, the technology excels at incorporating strong visuals into the surroundings of the user(s), which provides an opportunity to design enticing experiences for both learning and collaboration. For this purpose, it is important to identify what collaborative experiences have been created in the past with [AR](#), what learning goals align with the technology and what challenges in design and development can be expected.

This chapter explores these questions and themes across three sections. The first section tackles the topic of collaboration, how it is defined and measured, different implementations in the classroom, perceived benefits, common challenges and lessons learned from previous projects. The second section presents a systematic literature review aimed at identifying the use of [AR](#) as a tool for education, how the technology has evolved, which elements of the technology have derived in success stories, and which have become challenges. The final section will combine both subjects and explore the literature for previous experiences using collaborative [AR](#), both in education and in other fields.

2.1 Collaborative Learning

2.1.1 Collaboration as a Transversal Skill

The subject of CL is wide and can be tackled through different angles. For instance, we can talk about collaboration as an isolated term, and relate it to similar concepts like teamwork, cooperation and intrapersonal skills. In need of a definition, the approach taken by Andriessen and Baker (2020) is very complete. The authors state that “(...) collaboration means developing, in an equal and mutually respectful way, a shared view of a situation”. Is a simple definition that implies two important things. First, collaborators find themselves in equal terms, there is a sense of equality and mutual correspondence. Authoritative or hierarchical relations hardly produce collaborative settings. Second, collaboration goes beyond cooperation, beyond working together to fulfil a goal. Collaboration implies building, through time, a shared view. The group has a shared set of goals, purpose and values. The classical definition of collaboration proposed by Roschelle and Teasley (1995) also complements this idea by stating that cooperation involves the division of labour among participants, of individual responsibility, while collaboration is a coordinated effort to solve the problem. Echoing this distinction between collaboration and similar ideas like cooperation or teamwork, Salmons (2019) states that collaboration is a process that needs to constantly be managed, while teamwork is a more *natural* or *improvised* way of working together when needed.

Andriessen and Baker (2020) later expand all these ideas by stating how collaboration is built through time in three different dimensions. In a personal sense, we collaborate because we gain something from it, or in the worst-case scenario, because we need to do it. Our goals align with those of others, creating a second inter-personal dimension, in which we also care about the relationship we create with others and the social advantages we obtain from the collaboration. Finally, with strong inter-personal interactions, we create a group dynamic, in which decisions are taken beyond the individual level and align with the necessities of the group. This evolution can be fractal, which means that after a strong group has been created, it can be developed in a fourth dimension, an inter-group relationship in which several tight-knitted groups collaborate in a shared purpose within a bigger system.

Now is possible to build an initial definition to be use as conceptual backbone. Collaboration will be understood as: the process in which a group of people build a set of values, shared views and coordinated efforts to fulfil a purpose or reach a goal. This definition considers the most important aspects highlighted previously by other authors: collaboration goes beyond just coordinating tasks because is strongly linked to building relationships and communities, therefore, it is a very social skill. Collaboration is not a single action, is a process that needs time and effort to be constructed. Finally, collaboration is aimed, it needs a purpose or a goal. More important, that goal needs to be shared among the collaborators instead of being imposed. Collaboration can only be developed when all the members of the group find themselves as equals and share the perceived value or the necessity of working towards that aim.

It is possible to add more elements to the definition, creating a wider and stronger framework, if we analyse the concept of collaboration from other perspectives and in different contexts. For instance, collaboration can be viewed as a skill to be developed within the context of professional development and employability.

As stated by Crant (2000), it is common for a workspace to seek in a professional a proper balance between theory and knowledge, that is, the information gathered through practice and experience. This position can be read as employers seeking people that have built a career rather than only have a profession. For employees, it means that they must build that career identity: the right set of skills, experience and personal traits that show value beyond a profession. Additionally, employers seek candidates that can properly response to a variable environment, either due to high pressure or a fast-moving market. Employees must then demonstrate personal adaptability, a willingness to explore, and life-long learning values. Finally, employers seek for the ability to properly construct and use the surrounding social context, the employee needs to build social capital by cultivating abilities in cooperation, networking and teamwork.

This framework shows the importance on adding value to the professional profile, and highlights skills related to adaptability and collaboration as key value pointers. The framework also relates easily to other popular concepts like social intelligence, personal development and problem-solving attitudes, all part of what has been known as transversal skills. The UNESCO defines transversal skills as those that can be used in a wide variety of situations and work settings (UNESCO, 2014) and are valuable for their general applicability and transferability. These skills can be organized in five broad categories:

- Critical and innovative thinking.
- Interpersonal skills.
- Intrapersonal skills.
- Global citizenship.
- Media and information literacy.

To understand better the type of abilities that the previous categories encompass, we can extract some ideas from diverse sources in the literature, a set of studies focused in understanding the work market in different contextual variations of geography, professional field, years of experience and even nature of the job-hunting process (Abir et al., 2024; Boahin & Hofman, 2013; Garst et al., 2019; Huynh et al., 2024; Llorens et al., 2017; Nadarajah, 2021; Ng et al., 2021; Smaldone et al., 2022; Zhang et al., 2024). This sample of literature shows the type of skills most demanded by employers around the world. Although skills that are considered *hard*, or better described as field-specific are understandably diverse, there is almost a complete coordination related to *soft*, transversal skills. These skills are common to all contexts and independent of the region or work field. Figure 2.1 shows a visual distribution of the most common transversal skills sought after in potential candidates, extracted from the studies mentioned above.

Despite being a small sample, the data shows a clear emphasis on relational skills, and it seems to portray the added value of hiring and developing people with high communication abilities, teamwork, good social interactions, and flexibility (Al Asefer & Zainal Abidin, 2021).

Another important sentiment that can be extracted from all the literature mentioned is a perceived discordance between the skills and abilities focused on by high educational

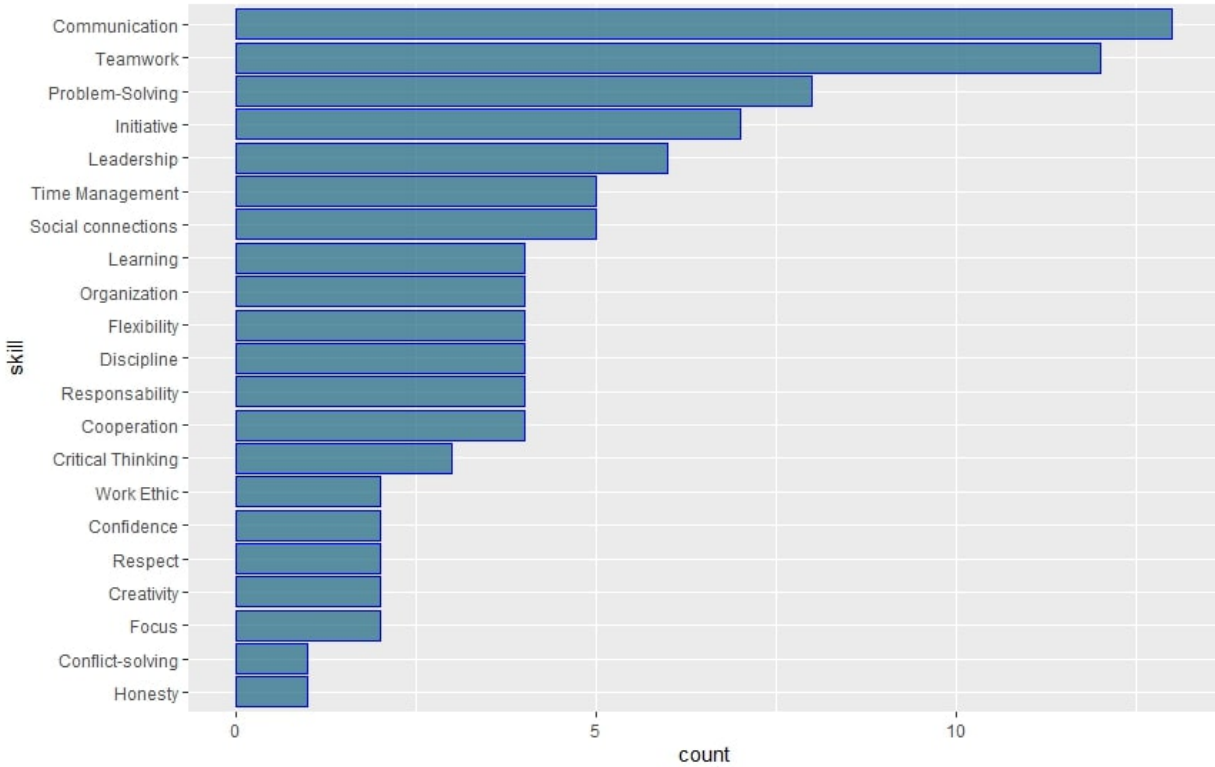


Figure 2.1: Most common soft skills identified

organisations and those sought after by companies and employees, as identified so far in this section (Damoah et al., 2021; Ng et al., 2021).

Tulgan (2023) identifies specifically three soft skills missing in young workers: professionalism, critical thinking and teamwork. Tulgan argues that this gap is closely related to a generational and technological shift where there is a lower need to develop communication skills because we have offloaded most of our communicational needs into electronical devices (mails, meetings, conversation, social interactions), forgoing the opportunity to develop such skills in person.

Tulgan keeps explaining that in recent years *good old-fashioned* teamwork became an issue for young people, who have developed a different set of values that clash with those of previous generations. Where older generations built a long career as part of a company or institution, newer generations have little to no loyalty to a single employer, and they are more likely to search for better deals. Young professionals find little value in adapting to the ways and stablished institutions of a group when they know very well, they won't be there for too long.

Secondary and tertiary education programs are often seen as the main responsible agents in the development of skills deemed crucial for the general professional life (Kechagias, 2011) and is in this light that modern curricula in almost all disciplines now have a higher emphasis on building those transferable skills (Earl et al., 2021). This is not without problems, and there is a noticeable consensus that teaching such skills is not a trivial task (McCale, 2008). Several factors influence the ability of a curriculum to provide such learning pathways. Most

common problems are related to how little educators are prepared to incorporate those skills in their classrooms (Kemp & Seagraves, 1995), the costs of adapting the curriculum, training the personnel and changing old mindsets to effectively provide the space to create such learning (Chadha, 2006).

Considering these extra contextual elements, it is possible to modify the previous definition of collaboration as follows: Collaboration is the skill to work as part of a group by identifying, building and acting upon a set of values, shared views and coordinated efforts to fulfil a purpose or reach a goal. This modified definition not only states a set of characteristics of what the process of collaborating implies, it frames it as a skill to be executed by each member of a group, and not as something that happens naturally when people gather. It also acknowledges the need to learn and develop such skills.

The theoretical framework around collaborative learning can be expanded by exploring the definition of a second concept, that of Communities of Practice, with the intention of later linking this idea with the general definition of collaboration built so far and the approach proposed by this project to use it as an educational tool.

2.1.2 Communities of Practice

A term proposed by Lave and Wenger (1991), a Community of Practice (CoP) can be defined as a set of mechanisms of situated learning used by communities to transmit knowledge internally, especially to newer members. These communities are formed around a focused domain and were initially used to describe the learning process used in different trades like craftsmanship and health practices. The meaning of the term has been broadening with time and can be applicable to any group that gathers towards a common goal over an extended period, that is, enough time for several generations of members to come and go.

Strongly linked to CoP is the idea of legitimate peripheral participation. This can be defined as the process in which newcomers learn mostly through observation and gradual participation with their senior peers (McDonald & Cater-Steel, 2017). CoP are used to give some structure to the process of informal learning, especially the type of learning found outside of academy, and which is more linked to professional practice, personal development and the relationships forged in the day-to-day activities with peers and a community in general.

A healthy CoP is one that is generated naturally due to the interaction of a community around a specific domain. It is different from a task force or team of people gathered around a goal or a problem in the sense that the general objective of a CoP is more undefined in terms of time, is focused more on the practice rather than the goal or product itself and is constituted by a social community rather than by just a collaborating team of people. These are the three fundamental elements that define a CoP: a domain, a community and a established practice, as described in Figure 2.2.

The domain is the knowledge base in which the community chooses to work because it offers value or just interest in general. New members come voluntarily and interact with elder members gaining experience in the practice, with the expectation of eventually gaining mastery.

The community is a group of people that can be driven by complex social dynamics. The community will create norms, stratifications and behaviours over time. The community is

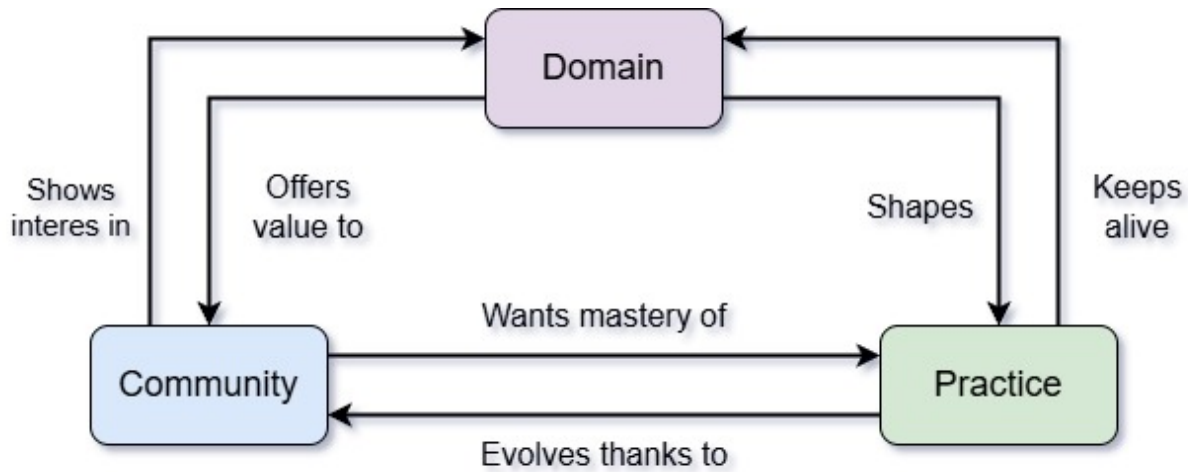


Figure 2.2: Elements of a Community of Practice

expected to be in a constant flux of members and to evolve with time, in terms of social interactions and the relationship it has with the domain.

The practice is an integrated set of activities and knowledge executed and transmitted by the community to create mastery over them. Some CoP focus more on nurturing members into the mastery of the practice, while other focus more on the transmission and preservation of the knowledge generated, as noted by Klein et al. (2005).

CoP have shown to be the cornerstones in the development of informal and social learning, leadership development and organizational change (Anderson & McCune, 2013). Often, high indexes of performance and employee satisfaction are present when a CoP has been identified and nurtured within the informal structure of an organization (Blackmore et al., 2010). Also, they have proven to be valuable integration, communication, and identity reinforcement tools in communities with a high degree of disparity or diversity among members (Hildreth & Kimble, 2004).

A particular emphasis in the idea of nurturing a CoP is important. A community can perish due to lack of proper nourishment or caused by artificial intervention. Previously it was noted that it is not possible to force the creation of a CoP, new members must voluntarily engage in legitimate ways with the practice. But even when a community develops and grows in members, and its value is acknowledged and sought after, forced practices that run in contradiction with the spirit of a CoP can end up killing it. Authors like Ardichvili et al. (2003) and Brown and Duguid (1991) have analysed the lifecycles of successful and failed CoP inside the organizational practice of many and varied industries, from insurance brokers to high education institutes. Of all the key factors identified in the failure or disappearance of a CoP, it is useful to highlight the following ones:

- Not allowing enough time for members of the community to form relationships and sustain them. This can be due to frequent administrative reorganization or the prevalence of temporary or part-time staff.
- A culture of tight management, where every aspect of the practice is highly standardized

and supervised, and there is no possibility for a natural development of the practice due to the relationships formed in the community.

- A culture of highly individualized work, either due to the very nature of the practice or because of other factors, like a very competitive environment. This inhibits collaboration and discourages collective engagement.
- Practices with extreme time or performance pressures, which leaves little time to develop a collective or communicative environment.
- Spatially fragmented work, so that there is no opportunity to establish a relationship, or because there is not a common, unsupervised space for the community to gather.
- Communication and activities are heavily mediated by technology or even other people. This makes interactions (arguably) less immediate and intense, therefore, lacking importance.

So far, all the elements that have been illustrated paint the concept of a [CoP](#) as a natural-occurring social structure formed around the need of preserving, communicating and nourishing knowledge within a well established community. It is a manifestation of informal education that thrives and offers the best results when acknowledged at an organizational level but not tampered with (Brown & Duguid, [1991](#)), and when given enough resources to grow and evolve (Klein & Connell, [2008](#)).

Given the importance of naturality and informality within the definition of a [CoP](#), it is possible to see how these fundamental elements can be at odds with the expectations and common practices found in more traditional and institutionalized education, where learning is more structured, participation is hardly voluntary and collaborative processes are more task-focused rather than long-term approaches to the practice. These issues will be acknowledged in the following section.

2.1.3 Communities of Practice and Education

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